Force, fraud, oppression, looting are openly displayed without any attempt at concealment, and it requires an effort to discover within this tangle of political violence and contests of power the stern laws of the economic process.'

Her core insight (1968:397), as distinct from framings by Lenin, Bukharin, Hilferding, Hobson and others of her era, was to show that 'Capital cannot accumulate without the aid of non-capitalist' relations and 'Only the continuous and progressive disintegration of non-capitalist organisation makes accumulation of capital possible'. This process, in which 'capital feeds on the ruins' of the non-capitalist social relations, amounts to 'eating it up. Historically, the accumulation of capital is a kind of metabolism between capitalism and those pre-capitalist methods of production without which it cannot go on and which, in this light, it corrodes and assimilates.'

This process is amplified during periods of desperation intrinsic to capitalist crisis, Luxemburg (1968:76) observed, drawing on Marx's classical theory about 'perpetual overproduction', characterised by 'the ceaseless flow of capital from one branch of production to another, and finally in the periodical and cyclical swings of reproduction between overproduction and crisis.' At that point, as Luxemburg (1968:327) insists, the core countries reveal 'the deep and fundamental antagonism between the capacity to consume and the capacity to produce in a capitalist society, a conflict resulting from the very accumulation of capital which periodically bursts out in crises and spurs capital on to a continual extension of the market' (see Bond, Chitonge and Hopfmann 2007 for contemporary Southern African applications of Luxemburg's thesis).

With the current renewal of this process – crisis, extension of the market, and amplified capitalist–noncapitalist super-exploitative relations – serving as the basis for renewed imperialism, Harvey (2003) adds a new layer to this argument: 'The opening up of global markets in both commodities and capital created openings for other states to insert themselves into the global economy, first as absorbers but then as producers of surplus capitals. They then became competitors on the world stage. What might be called "sub-imperialisms" arose … Each developing centre of capital accumulation sought out systematic spatio-temporal fixes for its own surplus capital by defining territorial spheres of influence.'

The idea of the 'spatio-temporal fix' requires elaboration, again because this notion hard-wires capital's geographic needs and territorial powers within the system's very logic. Harvey (1992) identifies 'a cascading and proliferating series of spatio-temporal fixes' to persistent economic crises, which are invoked so as to extend capitalism geographically and across time, usually facilitated by dramatic financial expansion. The role of banks in core and even sub-imperial countries